

# Querying & Parsing Logs

---

**Series:** OPLOGS | **Notebook:** 5 of 8 | **Created:** December 2025 | **Last Updated:** 01/28/2026

## DQL Fundamentals and DPL Pattern Matching

---

This notebook covers DQL query syntax, filtering, string matching, and DPL (Dynatrace Pattern Language) for extracting structured data from logs.

---

## Table of Contents

---

1. [DQL Fundamentals](#)
  2. [Filtering Logs](#)
  3. [String Matching Functions](#)
  4. [Field Selection and Transformation](#)
  5. [DPL \(Dynatrace Pattern Language\) Parsing](#)
  6. [Working with JSON Logs](#)
  7. [Null Handling](#)
  8. [Advanced Parsing Examples](#)
  9.  [Summary](#)
  10.  [Next Steps](#)
  11.  [References](#)
- 

## Prerequisites

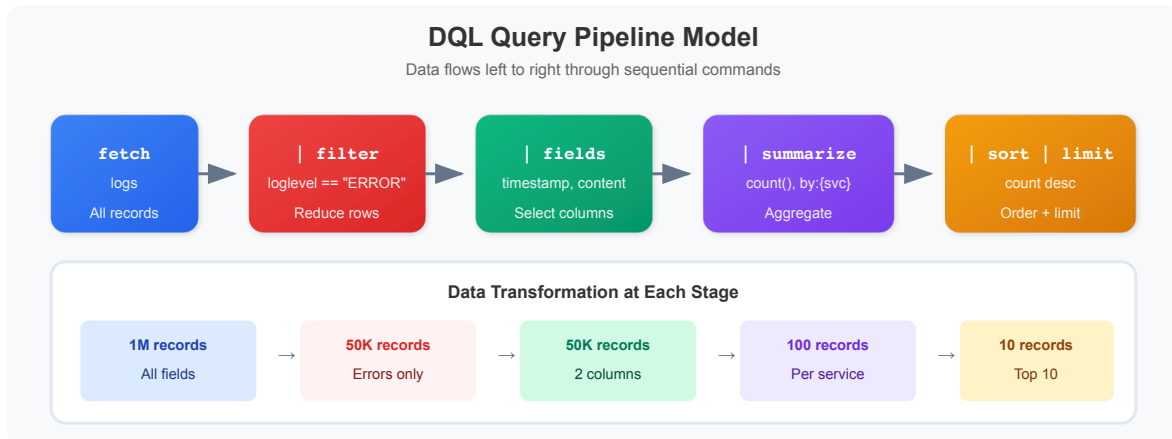
---

-  Access to a Dynatrace environment with log data

-  Completed OPLOGS-01 through OPLOGS-04
-  Basic understanding of regular expressions (helpful)

## 1. DQL Fundamentals

### Query Structure



```

fetch logs, from: now() - 1h           // Data source and time range
| filter <condition>                    // Filter records
| fields <field1>, <field2>              // Select fields
| sort <field> desc                     // Order results
| limit 100                            // Limit output
  
```

### Critical DQL Rules (DQL ≠ SQL)

|  DQL Syntax |  SQL Syntax |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <code>filter status == "ERROR"</code>                                                          | <code>WHERE status = 'ERROR'</code>                                                            |
| <code>in(field, {"a", "b"})</code>                                                             | <code>field IN ('a', 'b')</code>                                                               |
| <code>summarize {count = count()}</code>                                                       | <code>SELECT COUNT(*)</code>                                                                   |
| <code>isNull(field)</code>                                                                     | <code>field IS NULL</code>                                                                     |

```

// Basic log query - explore recent logs
fetch logs, from: now() - 1h
| fields timestamp, content, loglevel, dt.entity.host
| limit 10
  
```

```
// Query with time range options
fetch logs, from: now() - 24h, to: now() - 12h
| summarize {count = count()}, by: {loglevel}
| sort count desc
```

## 2. Filtering Logs

### Comparison Operators

| Operator                               | Description  | Example                          |
|----------------------------------------|--------------|----------------------------------|
| <code>==</code>                        | Equals       | <code>loglevel == "ERROR"</code> |
| <code>!=</code>                        | Not equals   | <code>status != "NONE"</code>    |
| <code>&gt;</code> , <code>&gt;=</code> | Greater than | <code>count &gt; 100</code>      |
| <code>&lt;</code> , <code>&lt;=</code> | Less than    | <code>duration &lt; 1000</code>  |

### Logical Operators

| Operator         | Description      | Example                                                |
|------------------|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| <code>AND</code> | Both conditions  | <code>loglevel == "ERROR" AND isNotNull(host)</code>   |
| <code>OR</code>  | Either condition | <code>loglevel == "ERROR" OR loglevel == "WARN"</code> |
| <code>NOT</code> | Negate           | <code>NOT contains(content, "health")</code>           |

```
// Filter by log level
fetch logs, from: now() - 1h
| filter loglevel == "ERROR"
| fields timestamp, content, dt.entity.host
| limit 20
```

```
// Multiple conditions with AND/OR
fetch logs, from: now() - 1h
| filter (loglevel == "ERROR" OR loglevel == "WARN")
      AND isNotNull(dt.entity.host)
| summarize {count = count()}, by: {loglevel, dt.entity.host}
| sort count desc
| limit 15
```

```
// Filter using in() for multiple values
fetch logs, from: now() - 1h
| filter in(loglevel, {"ERROR", "WARN", "INFO"})
| summarize {count = count()}, by: {loglevel}
| sort count desc
```

### 3. String Matching Functions

| Function                                | Description             | Example                                                   |
|-----------------------------------------|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| <code>contains(str, substr)</code>      | Substring match         | <code>contains(content, "error")</code>                   |
| <code>startsWith(str, prefix)</code>    | Prefix match            | <code>startsWith(content, "[ERROR]")</code>               |
| <code>endsWith(str, suffix)</code>      | Suffix match            | <code>endsWith(content, "failed")</code>                  |
| <code>matchesPhrase(str, phrase)</code> | Word boundary match     | <code>matchesPhrase(content, "connection refused")</code> |
| <code>matchesValue(str, pattern)</code> | Exact or wildcard match | <code>matchesValue(host, "web-*")</code>                  |

```
// Search for specific content patterns
fetch logs, from: now() - 1h
| filter contains(content, "Exception")
| fieldsAdd content_preview = substring(content, from: 0, to: 100)
| fields timestamp, content_preview, dt.entity.host
| limit 15
```

```
// Use matchesPhrase for word-boundary matching
fetch logs, from: now() - 1h
| filter matchesPhrase(content, "connection")
| fieldsAdd content_preview = substring(content, from: 0, to: 120)
| summarize {count = count()}, by: {content_preview}
| sort count desc
| limit 10
```

```
// Exclude patterns with NOT
fetch logs, from: now() - 1h
| filter loglevel == "ERROR"
| filter NOT matchesPhrase(content, "health")
| filter NOT matchesPhrase(content, "heartbeat")
| fieldsAdd content_preview = substring(content, from: 0, to: 100)
| summarize {count = count()}, by: {content_preview}
| sort count desc
| limit 10
```

## 4. Field Selection and Transformation

### Field Commands

| Command                   | Description                 |
|---------------------------|-----------------------------|
| <code>fields</code>       | Select specific fields only |
| <code>fieldsAdd</code>    | Add computed fields         |
| <code>fieldsRemove</code> | Remove fields               |

```
// Add computed fields
fetch logs, from: now() - 1h
| filter loglevel == "ERROR"
| fieldsAdd severity = if(contains(content, "critical"), "CRITICAL",
                        else: if(contains(content, "fatal"), "FATAL",
                        else: "ERROR"))
| fieldsAdd content_length = stringLength(content)
| fields timestamp, severity, content_length, dt.entity.host
| limit 20
```

```
// String manipulation functions
fetch logs, from: now() - 1h
| filter isNotNull(k8s.namespace.name)
| fieldsAdd pod_short = substring(k8s.pod.name, from: 0, to: 30)
| fields timestamp, k8s.namespace.name, pod_short, loglevel
| limit 10
```

## 5. DPL (Dynatrace Pattern Language) Parsing

DPL extracts structured data from unstructured log content.

### DPL Matchers

| Matcher | Description              | Matches           |
|---------|--------------------------|-------------------|
| INT     | Integer                  | 42 , -17          |
| DOUBLE  | Decimal                  | 3.14 , -0.5       |
| IPADDR  | IP address               | 192.168.1.1 , ::1 |
| LD      | Line data (to delimiter) | Any text          |
| WORD    | Word characters          | hello , user123   |
| SPACE   | Whitespace               | spaces, tabs      |
| JSON    | JSON structure           | {"key": "value"}  |

### Pattern Syntax

| Syntax            | Description             |
|-------------------|-------------------------|
| MATCHER:fieldname | Extract to named field  |
| MATCHER           | Match but don't extract |
| MATCHER?          | Optional matcher        |
| 'literal'         | Match exact string      |
| (opt1 opt2)       | Match alternatives      |

```
// Parse log level from content (e.g., "[ERROR] message")
fetch logs, from: now() - 1h
| filter startsWith(content, "[")
| parse content, "'[' LD:parsed_level ']"
| filter isNotNull(parsed_level)
| summarize {count = count()}, by: {parsed_level}
| sort count desc
| limit 10
```

```
// Parse HTTP-style logs
// Example: GET /api/users 200 45ms
fetch logs, from: now() - 1h
| filter contains(content, "GET") OR contains(content, "POST")
| parse content, "LD:method SPACE '/' LD:path SPACE INT:status_code"
| filter isNotNull(status_code)
| summarize {count = count()}, by: {method, status_code}
| sort count desc
| limit 15
```

```
// Parse key-value pairs
// Example: "user=john action=login status=success"
fetch logs, from: now() - 1h
| parse content, "'user=' LD:username SPACE"
| filter isNotNull(username)
| summarize {count = count()}, by: {username}
| sort count desc
| limit 10
```

```
// Parse IP addresses from logs
fetch logs, from: now() - 1h
| parse content, "IPADDR:client_ip"
| filter isNotNull(client_ip)
| summarize {count = count()}, by: {client_ip}
| sort count desc
| limit 15
```

## 6. Working with JSON Logs

---

Many applications emit JSON-formatted logs. DQL provides tools to work with JSON content.

```
// Find JSON-formatted logs
fetch logs, from: now() - 1h
| filter startsWith(content, "{")
| fieldsAdd content_preview = substring(content, from: 0, to: 150)
| summarize {count = count()}, by: {content_preview}
| sort count desc
| limit 10
```

```
// Parse JSON and extract fields
fetch logs, from: now() - 1h
| filter startsWith(content, "{")
| parse content, "JSON:json_data"
| filter isNotNull(json_data)
| fields timestamp, json_data
| limit 10
```

```
// Access nested JSON fields
fetch logs, from: now() - 1h
| filter startsWith(content, "{")
| parse content, "JSON:json_data"
| filter isNotNull(json_data)
| fieldsAdd error_type = json_data[errorType]
| fieldsAdd status_val = json_data[status]
| filter isNotNull(status_val)
| summarize {count = count()}, by: {status_val, error_type}
| sort count desc
| limit 15
```

## 7. Null Handling

DQL uses three-valued logic. `NULL` comparisons require special functions.

| ❌ Wrong                    | ✅ Correct                     |
|----------------------------|-------------------------------|
| <code>field == null</code> | <code>isNull(field)</code>    |
| <code>field != null</code> | <code>isNotNull(field)</code> |

```
// Check for null values
fetch logs, from: now() - 1h
| summarize {
    total = count(),
    with_host = countIf(isNotNull(dt.entity.host)),
    without_host = countIf(isNull(dt.entity.host)),
    with_namespace = countIf(isNotNull(k8s.namespace.name)),
    without_namespace = countIf(isNull(k8s.namespace.name))
}
```

```
// Use coalesce for default values
fetch logs, from: now() - 1h
| fieldsAdd effective_level = coalesce(loglevel, status, "UNKNOWN")
| summarize {count = count()}, by: {effective_level}
| sort count desc
```

## 8. Advanced Parsing Examples

---

```
// Parse exception patterns
fetch logs, from: now() - 24h
| filter contains(content, "Exception") OR contains(content, "Error")
| parse content, "LD:exception_type 'Exception'"
| filter isNotNull(exception_type)
| summarize {count = count()}, by: {exception_type}
| sort count desc
| limit 15
```

```
// Parse with optional fields
// Matches: "error code=123" or "error code=123 message=failed"
fetch logs, from: now() - 1h
| filter contains(content, "error")
| parse content, "'error' (SPACE 'code=' INT:error_code)? (SPACE 'message='
LD:error_msg)?"
| filter isNotNull(error_code)
| summarize {count = count()}, by: {error_code}
| sort count desc
| limit 10
```

```
// Parse alternative formats
// Matches: "user=john", "username=john"
fetch logs, from: now() - 1h
| parse content, "('user='|'username=') LD:user_value"
| filter isNotNull(user_value)
| summarize {count = count()}, by: {user_value}
| sort count desc
| limit 10
```



## Summary

---

In this notebook, you learned:

- ✓ **DQL fundamentals** - Query structure and syntax rules
  - ✓ **Filtering** - Comparison operators, logical operators, in()
  - ✓ **String matching** - contains, matchesPhrase, startsWith
  - ✓ **Field manipulation** - fieldsAdd, computed fields
  - ✓ **DPL parsing** - Matchers (INT, LD, IPADDR, JSON)
  - ✓ **JSON handling** - Parsing and accessing nested fields
  - ✓ **Null handling** - isNull, isNotNull, coalesce
- 



## Next Steps

---

Continue to **OPLOGS-06: Topology & Entity Context** to learn about entity context and relationships.

---



## References

---

- [DQL Reference](#)
- [DQL Functions](#)
- [Dynatrace Pattern Language](#)
- [DPL Architect Tool](#)

---

*This notebook was AI-generated from community-submitted and publicly available sources. This notebook series is not officially supported by Dynatrace. Always verify information against official Dynatrace documentation.*